The *hunkar* (a war cry) rally had been planned by the state BJP for months. All over Patna, large posters of Narendra Modi had come up at every vantage point—the city was dressed up to receive a special guest. The BJP had offered to take correspondents from Delhi to Patna for the rally. The CNN-IBN bureau chief in Patna, Prabhakar Kumar, was peeved and made his unhappiness clear. 'Why do you always need to send reporters from Delhi to cover a major event, sir? I am sure we can handle it on our own here,' he complained.

I tried to reason with him that this was a major news event. 'What if there is a bomb blast at the site, Prabhakar, what will we do then? Surely, we need a stronger team on the ground,' was my defence. Little did I or my Patna colleague know that the words would prove eerily prophetic.

The rally was scheduled for noon but being a Sunday, the crowds had begun to gather from early morning at the maidan. The BJP had organized buses to bring in people from neighbouring districts for a show of strength; the trains, too, were jam-packed. 'This will be the biggest ever rally in the history of Bihar,' the BJP spokesperson Rajiv Pratap Rudy told us.

'Big' in Bihar means gargantuan—the Biharis love their politics. In no state is the political discourse as animated as it can be in Bihar. Involvement in politics is almost a cottage industry for many Biharis. I had once attended a Lalu Prasad 'Lathi' rally in 2003 against George Bush's Iraq invasion. I never understood why nearly 2 lakh people would gather to protest against a war in a distant land, but they did. This time, Gandhi Maidan was poised for another massive show with some estimates suggesting an audience in excess of 2 lakhs.

The first blast went off in the toilet at platform ten of Patna junction at around 9.30 a.m. One person was injured. It sparked a scare but remained a news flash. The station, after all, was far away from the Gandhi Maidan. Two hours later, we knew we were dealing with a big breaking news story—between 11.40 a.m. and 12.15 p.m., four blasts ripped through areas in and around the maidan. A final blast took place while BJP leader Shahnawaz Hussain was speaking on stage. Hussain thought it was a 'cracker'. It wasn't. This was no longer just another incident on the